

Judge William T. Newman, Jr.

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By [Arlington Historical Society](#)



Judge William T. Newman

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Born in the early 1950s, Judge Newman grew up in Arlington, Virginia, and received a Bachelor of Fine Arts degree with honors from Ohio University in 1972. After graduating from OHIO, he worked as an actor while saving up money for law school. He then went on to receive his Juris Doctorate from the Catholic University's Columbus School of Law. From 1977 to 1980, he was Staff Trademark Attorney with the U.S. Department of Commerce.

In 1980, he entered the private practice of law and eventually became a partner in the firm of Carpenter, Newman, Martin, Berkowitz and Garnes. In 1983, he founded the Northern Virginia Black Attorneys Association. Prior to his appointment to the bench, Judge Newman was involved in local politics.

In 1987, he was elected to the Arlington County Board, becoming the first African American elected to the board since Reconstruction. On the Board, one of his signature policies was establishing the County's Human Rights Commission, and he was known for advocating for public safety and resources for drug abuse. In 1990, he was elected as Chairman of the County Board, becoming the first Black person to hold the position in the 20th century.

Newman grew up in the Nauck community of Arlington and attended Hoffman-Boston until the school closed in 1964 following desegregation. He trained and worked as both a lawyer and an actor, and has performed in soap operas, film, and theater performances. In 1993, Newman was appointed to the 17th Judicial Circuit Court, covering Arlington County and the city of Falls Church. In 2003, he became chief judge of the County Circuit Court, where he continues to serve today.

Since Newman's tenure, there have been three African American members of the County Board. Charles P. Monroe was elected to the Board in 1999 and served until his death in 2003. He had begun his first turn as Board chair at the time of his death. Christian Dorsey was elected to the County Board in 2015. He served as Board chair in 2019. Julius D. "JD" Spain, Sr. was elected to the Board in 2024.

Judge Newman passed away on February 10, 2026, leaving a legacy of judicial service. The Arlington County Board remembered him as “a pillar of our community” in a joint statement. “Judge Newman was a remarkable Arlingtonian, whose contributions to our community are groundbreaking, vast, and inspiring,” Board members said. “His legacy will continue to serve as a beaming example of public service, leadership, and dedication to Arlington.”



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